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Wildfire impacts continued to smolder as normal life returned to the city

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Editor's Note: The Daily Press is currently running it's annual Year in Review coverage summarizing the news from 2025. Each month will have it's own summary posted to smdp.com and available in print.

February

School board stumped by low grades and high test scores

SMMUSD officials expressed concern regarding over 800 secondary students receiving D or F grades in math during the fall semester, despite improved standardized test scores. Board members were confused by the disparity between classroom grades and testing benchmarks, prompting discussions on grading equity and consistency across the district.

Trump administration rollout leaves school officials disappointed

SMMUSD Superintendent Dr. Antonio Shelton reaffirmed the district's commitment to being a safe zone for all students following Trump executive orders targeting diversity education and prioritizing school choice. The district plans to adopt a new resolution supporting immigrant students and ensuring no enrollment barriers exist.

State social media bill receives expected legal challenge

A federal court granted a stay halting SB 976, California's law banning "addictive feeds" for minors without parental consent. NetChoice, an advocacy group, challenged the bill on First Amendment grounds, delaying its implementation. The bill aimed to curb algorithmic feeds associated with addiction and mental health harm in children.

Olympic High School students get a jump on college

Santa Monica College launched a dual enrollment program at Olympic High School, offering courses like photography and counseling. The initiative allows high school students to earn college credits and explore career paths while still attending their regular classes, aiming to support student well-being and academic communication.

Residents of Topanga Canyon protest against PCH toxic debris removal site

Approximately 30 protesters gathered at Topanga Beach to oppose the EPA's decision to place a toxic debris sorting site from the Palisades Fire at the former Topanga Ranch Motel location near Topanga Creek. The facility, set to operate 24/7 for up to three months, raised concerns about contamination leaking into the creek and ocean. Residents objected to processing Los Angeles debris at the site, noting the EPA's preferred Will Rogers Beach location had been denied. EPA's Rusty Harris-Bishop explained precautions included gravel pads and sealed containers, acknowledging residents felt excluded from decision-making. The site, part of Topanga State Park, was previously designated for lagoon restoration.

Fire, flood risks remain high in CA compared to other states

A new study by DJC Law ranked California second nationwide for natural disaster likelihood, trailing only Texas. The state led in future wildfire probability at 13.89%, having experienced 101,760 fires from 2010-2022—over 10,000 more than Texas. California tied for sixth in flood probability at 3.65%, following the devastating 2022-2023

atmospheric river season that caused 22 fatalities and 6,000 evacuations. The state ranked 20th for tornado probability at 0.58%. The California Legislative Analyst's Office attributed wildfire risk to seasonal rainfall, vegetation types, weather patterns, and increased development in fire-prone areas. Heavy rain was forecast for Los Angeles Wednesday, raising mudslide concerns in burn scar areas.

Teacher arrested for relationship with student

Santa Monica Police arrested Ingo Horst Gaida, 58, of Los Angeles, for an inappropriate relationship with a 16-year-old female Santa Monica High School student. Following an investigation, detectives determined the science teacher and student had been engaged in inappropriate activities since late 2024 at multiple locations throughout Los Angeles County. On February 5, SMPD detectives served arrest and search warrants, taking Gaida into custody on misdemeanor charges of annoying or molesting a child under 18 and contributing to the delinquency of a minor. He was released with a citation and promise to appear. Gaida had no prior criminal history. The case was filed with the Santa Monica City Attorney's Office.

Businesses physically unharmed by Palisades fire are getting burned by ongoing economic troubles

Santa Monica businesses experienced severe economic impacts from the Palisades Fire despite the city avoiding physical damage. Several restaurants closed, with many reporting sales comparable to early COVID-19 levels. Beach businesses were hardest hit due to environmental fears but Montana Avenue merchants lost their entire Palisades customer base. The city waived February outdoor dining fees, costing $80,000 in municipal revenue. Loans and support were offered to some businesses and a few did relocate into Santa Monica.

New legislation from Sacramento looks to curb drunk driving

Assemblywoman Cottie Petrie-Norris introduced AB 366, requiring all first-time DUI offenders in California to install ignition interlock devices. The bill aims to reduce impaired driving deaths by preventing vehicles from starting if alcohol is detected on the driver's breath, closing a loophole in current expiration policies.

10-year-old Palisades girl keeps karate dream alive despite destruction of her dojo

Ten-year-old Eden Savoian won two bronze medals at the International Martial Arts Competition in Las Vegas on February 1, despite losing her Pacific Palisades home and dojo in the recent fires. The green belt, who had trained for only 18 months at Gerry Blanck's Martial Arts Center, continued practicing at MuDo Integrated Martial Art in Santa Monica after both locations burned. Eden lost her medals, belts, and specialized equipment in the fire. Sensei Blanck provided her a new uniform, belt, and nunchucks for the competition. Over 180 other competitors had also lost homes. The tournament organizers replaced Eden's first medal lost in the fire.

PCH closed again due to fears of landslides

The Pacific Coast Highway closed over due to safety concerns ahead of predicted heavy rainfall. Caltrans and Los Angeles County Public Works closed the stretch from Chautauqua Boulevard to Carbon Beach Terrace after observing slide activity near Big Rock Drive and slippage below Porto Marina Way. Debris basins reached 80% capacity and required clearing before storms. The closure was restricted to essential workers only, though Palisades residents could access homes via Chautauqua Boulevard. Santa Monica Malibu Unified School District staff faced multi-hour commutes approaching Malibu from the north.

Affordable housing project at 14th, Wilshire receives ARB approval

The Santa Monica Architectural Review Board recommended approval February 3 for a 100% affordable housing project at 1217 14th Street. The Hollywood Community Housing Corporation proposal included 82 units—40 for permanent supportive housing and 40 for affordable senior housing aged 55-plus—plus two units for on-site staff. The six-story building would have subterranean parking for 42 vehicles. The ARB approved the design with one condition requiring additional upper-floor landscaping. Some residents criticized removal of an existing parking lot,

while others supported the project as crucial amid the post-Palisades Fire housing crisis. City Council had authorized negotiating a development agreement with HCHC in December.

Waymo introduces transit credit program for trips to Big Blue Bus stops

Autonomous rideshare company Waymo launched a pilot program offering credits to riders connecting to public transit stops en route to LAX. The initiative encourages multimodal transportation by incentivizing trips to Big Blue Bus stations, aiming to reduce traffic and emissions while integrating autonomous vehicles with public transit.

Learning loss still top concern for Malibu families

Santa Monica-Malibu Unified School District offered makeup instructional options for Malibu students who missed nearly all of January due to the Palisades Fire. Despite Governor Gavin Newsom's executive order waiving minimum instructional requirements, SMMUSD proposed online one-on-one tutoring (three hours weekly for six weeks starting February 17) or summer school (19 days from June 23-July 18). A parent survey of 160 responses showed 64.4% preferred tutoring, 25% chose summer school, and 10.6% needed no support. Webster Elementary School students all required makeup instruction after missing time from both the Palisades and Franklin fires. The district enrolled 128 displaced students from 322 requests.

Home of city's first Black physician now historical landmark

The Santa Monica Landmarks Commission designated the Tucker House at 1958 20th Street as a city landmark Monday. Nominated by the Santa Monica Conservancy and Quinn Research Center, the home belonged to Dr. Marcus O. Tucker, Santa Monica's first Black physician who practiced from 1931 until his death in 1944. The house, designed by distinguished architect Paul Revere Williams, met three landmark criteria for cultural, social and architectural significance. Tucker's wife Essie became a successful realtor, owning the Shore Hotel from 1956-1986. Their son Marcus Jr. served as Santa Monica's first Black deputy city attorney from 1963-1965. The designation received unanimous support from residents and community organizations.

Din Tai Fung opening

Din Tai Fung scheduled its Santa Monica Place opening for late February, with reservations available for a soft opening February 20-27. The acclaimed Chinese restaurant chain announced it would donate 100% of profits from soft opening and grand opening weeks to wildfire-affected local restaurants. The 10,615-square-foot location featured indoor and outdoor seating on the mall's third level with Pacific Ocean views. The Taiwan-based company operated seven Southern California restaurants among roughly 175 locations worldwide, earning Michelin stars for its signature xiao long bao soup dumplings. The opening provided a bright spot for Santa Monica Place, whose value had plunged 59% since 2017 amid tenant departures and mortgage default.

McKinley collaboration provides example of positive Prop 28 usage

McKinley Elementary School utilized Prop 28 arts funding to partner with ReDiscover Center for hands-on "PBL Workshop" classes. The funding also supported music education, theatre arts, and dance instruction across various SMMUSD grade levels, providing new equipment and professional experts to enhance student creativity.

PCH closures make more impacts on Malibu school commutes

SMMUSD officials addressed ongoing challenges for Malibu students and staff due to Pacific Coast Highway closures and power outages. The district explored solutions like generators and satellite internet while managing transportation difficulties caused by the Palisades Fire, emphasizing the need for reliable access to campuses.

Samohi, Saint Monica soccer still alive in playoff brackets

Local high school soccer teams, including Samohi and Saint Monica, advanced in the CIF Southern Section playoffs.

Samohi boys' soccer defeated Crossroads, while Saint Monica's Mariners continued a strong defensive streak to reach the divisional championship, shutting out multiple opponents along the way.

School board looks at Dashboard findings, preps for busy meeting

SMMUSD staff presented the 2024 California School Dashboard results, highlighting positive indicators in testing and graduation rates. However, progress for English Learners declined slightly, though the district remains above the state average. The board also reviewed plans to expand middle school sports programs.

Past, present, future of forestry examined by local museum

The Santa Monica History Museum's new exhibit, "Roots & Branches," explored the city's environmental history from a tree's perspective. It covered Indigenous history, urban forestry policies, and the impact of redlining on tree canopy density, while highlighting future plans for sustainable tree species in the city.

School bond dollars put to work with first Measure QS issuance

The SMMUSD Board approved the first $200 million issuance of Measure QS bonds. Funds were allocated for major facility improvements, including a new STEM building at John Adams Middle School and library updates at Roosevelt Elementary, alongside modernization projects at Lincoln Middle School.

Samohi students take fury to City Hall for fiery Trump protest

Over 50 Samohi students walked out of class to protest Trump administration policies targeting LGBTQ+ rights and immigrants. The demonstration at City Hall was part of a coordinated effort with other local schools to advocate for inclusivity and protest threats to diversity education funding. Superintendent Antonio Shelton and union leaders commended students for their civic engagement during the walkout. District officials reinforced their commitment to maintaining safe, inclusive schools despite federal threats regarding diversity initiatives, promising to continue teaching accurate history and supporting student advocacy.

Pacific Coast Highway reopens a month after Palisades Fire forced its closure

Caltrans reopened PCH through Santa Monica and Malibu following closures caused by the Palisades Fire. Motorists were advised to expect delays due to lane restrictions and safety controls remaining in place for repair crews, despite confusion over conflicting statements from local officials regarding the timeline.

Looting legislation passed

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel introduced AB 469 to make looting during a state of emergency a felony. The bill responded to thefts in fire evacuation zones, aiming to deter criminals who target vulnerable communities during disasters by increasing penalties and closing legal loopholes.

With Valentine's Day on the horizon, Most Loved voting opens for your favorite businesses

Santa Monica's annual "Most Loved" contest began, allowing residents to vote for favorite local businesses. The 12th annual event features new QR code voting tools to help businesses garner support and highlighted the importance of local enterprise to the community.

Local rotary groups pivot to fire relief fundraising

The Marina del Rey Rotary Club, established in July, launched wildfire relief efforts two days after the Palisades Fire began. Its January donation drive with Santa Monica Windjammers Yacht Club drew nearly 1,000 volunteer donors. The club's Heart of the Harbor initiative transported nearly 500,000 pounds of supplies to distribution points including Boys & Girls Clubs and churches. Corporate partner Niagara Water donated 80,000 pounds of water. The

Rotary Club of Santa Monica's 17th annual wine festival was set to benefit its Fire Relief Fund, which had already purchased $25,000 in supplies. The club raised $100,000 toward a $200,000 goal for local relief organizations.

Samohi orchestras to take Walt Disney Concert Hall stage

Santa Monica High School's Symphony and Chamber Orchestras were scheduled to perform at Walt Disney Concert Hall as part of the Los Angeles Philharmonic Association's Mahlerthon event. The daylong celebration of composer Gustav Mahler's music included Youth Orchestra Los Angeles, Inner City Youth Orchestra of Los Angeles, UCLA Philharmonia, USC Thornton Symphony and Colburn Orchestra. The orchestras planned to perform movements from Mahler's Fourth Symphony and Totenfeier. SMMUSD Visual and Performing Arts Coordinator Tom Whaley facilitated talks with the LA Phil about Samohi's inclusion after the orchestra program had previously impressed during a prior performance at the venue.

After fire delay, April date set for Malibu unification petition vote

The Malibu-Santa Monica school district unification process faced another delay when the Los Angeles County Office of Education postponed its January review due to the Palisades Fire. LACOE's Committee on School District Organization rescheduled final discussion and voting to April. The committee had been reviewing Malibu's feasibility study as part of its 2017 petition to split SMMUSD. Attorney Christine Wood, representing Malibu, emphasized residents' urgency for the split, particularly for rebuilding efforts. LACOE's Dr. Allison Deegan noted that even with committee approval, the petition would face years before reaching the State Board of Education.

Why store fire waste at Topanga and Will Rogers?

EPA Deputy Incident Commander Steve Calanog addressed concerns about using Will Rogers State Beach and Topanga State Park for Palisades Fire debris storage. He explained hazardous materials were sorted on-site, containerized, then transported to central locations where waste was consolidated for disposal across the Western United States. Direct transport would require thousands of trucks and astronomical costs. President Trump ordered bulk debris removal completed by February 25. The EPA installed barriers and containment systems on lined pads to prevent contamination, with continuous air and soil monitoring. Calanog said similar procedures from past fires, including Woolsey, produced no lasting contamination. Storage sites would remain operational for weeks to months after Phase 1 cleanup ended.

New plans call for an 18-story building high-rise at 1437 6th Street

Madison Realty Capital proposed an 18-story mixed-use development at 1437 6th Street. The project utilizes density bonuses to include 173 residential units, with 26 designated as affordable housing, replacing a former Builder's Remedy proposal.

1 dead and 1 hospitalized after stabbing near the Fairmont Hotel

A fatal stabbing occurred outside The Bungalow at the Fairmont Hotel, leaving one man dead and another injured. Police said it was an isolated incident and there was no danger to the public. Alfredo Quintero, Ricardo Quintero and Rogelio Arenas were arrested for the assault.

Suspect in January 15 Broadway homicide is now in custody

Police arrested Fabian Mendez for the fatal shooting of a homeless man on Broadway in January. The suspect allegedly chased the victim into the street following an argument before shooting him in the back, then fled the scene.

City Manager David White given traditional Santa Monica City send off

The City Council honored outgoing City Manager David White with a commendation and a replica road sign. White

was recognized for his leadership and integrity during his tenure before Elaine Polachek took over as interim manager.

US Army Corps of Engineers begin Phase 2 of the debris removal process in Pacific Palisades

Officials launched the second phase of debris removal in Pacific Palisades following the wildfires. The Army Corps of Engineers and EPA were coordinating efforts to clear hazardous materials and stabilize soil ahead of rain, utilizing pre-negotiated contracts to expedite the cleanup.

Wildfire debris build up on our beaches could potentially equate to an ecological disaster

Significant wildfire ash and debris have washed up on Santa Monica beaches, raising health concerns. Heal the Bay issued advisories, and officials tested materials for toxins like asbestos while warning residents to avoid the ash until safety can be confirmed.

Fred Fitness, the futuristic gym that offers 'AI-powered' personalized workouts, officially opens on 4th Street

A new gym, Fred Fitness, opened on 4th Street, featuring AI-powered personalized workouts. The facility aims to modernize the fitness experience through technology that adapts training regimens to individual users, celebrated with a ribbon-cutting by the Chamber of Commerce.

JAMS turns the page with learning hub modernization

John Adams Middle School celebrated its modernized library Wednesday with a ribbon-cutting ceremony. Funded by Measure SMS bonds and designed by Berliner Architects, the space featured flexible learning areas, collaboration rooms, upgraded technology, and an outdoor reading deck. Superintendent Dr. Antonio Shelton emphasized reading as foundational to learning. Chief Operations Officer Carey Upton announced upcoming projects including restroom improvements and a new STEM building planned for two-year construction beginning summer 2025.

Community Corporation celebrates Santa Monica's first modular affordable housing development

The Berkeley Station project, a 13-unit affordable housing development, was assembled using modular construction. This innovative building method aims to reduce costs and construction time for housing low-income families and at-risk youth, marking a first for the city.

Ursula's Costumes

Ursula Boschet, owner of legendary costume store Ursula's Costumes at 2516 Wilshire Boulevard, died of pancreatic cancer at 91. The store, which operated for over 50 years serving Hollywood productions and stars, closed permanently after a year of fiscal distress. Born in Stuttgart, Germany, Boschet emigrated to Los Angeles in 1962 and started her costume business after working at Disney. She was survived by two children, three grandchildren, and six great-grandchildren.

IKEA opens eagerly-awaited Santa Monica 'pick-up point'

IKEA opened a new "pick-up point" on Wilshire Blvd to serve Santa Monica customers. The smaller format store allows locals to collect online orders and access planning services without driving to larger warehouse locations, aiming to improve accessibility for the Westside.

Palisades High School moves to Santa Monica's Sears Building

Palisades Charter High School planned to temporarily relocate to the vacant Sears building at 302 Colorado Boulevard in Downtown Santa Monica following fire damage. The school planned to use temporary bungalows on its baseball field to eventually return students to the main campus in January 2026.

H&H Bagels opening

Famous New York brand H&H Bagels opened its first West Coast location on Montana Avenue. The shop aims to bring authentic New York-style bagels to the Westside, filling a gap in the local deli culture, with opening week profits donated to wildfire recovery.

Exclusive look at the Shore Hotel's newly renovated bar and restaurant

The Shore Hotel unveiled renovations including a redesigned bar and expanded outdoor dining. The updates aim to create a more lively street-side atmosphere while offering a sustainable, locally sourced menu to guests and locals alike.

EPA explainer: Why store fire waste at Topanga and Will Rogers?

The EPA explained its use of local beaches for temporary fire debris storage, citing safety protocols. Hazardous waste is sorted and containerized on-site before transport to these staging areas, with assurances of no long-term contamination to the sites used.

City Council: Gifts, parking on agenda

The City Council agenda includes discussions on a reparations study session and updates to gift rules for officials. Staff also recommended creating an ad hoc committee for the City Manager recruitment process and exploring raising individual campaign contribution limits.

Three arrested after fatal stabbing outside the Fairmont Bungalows

Police arrested three suspects in connection with the fatal stabbing at the Fairmont Hotel. The suspects, who have criminal histories, were apprehended following an investigation into the altercation that left one dead and another injured.

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